

Santiago & Luna

Art Direction Brief — for illustrator commission or AI-assisted generation

Why this brief exists: the current build uses CSS gradients as placeholder atmosphere. That is structure, not soul. This page is for the real ingredient the project still needs — hand-painted, museum-quality illustration. Once artwork exists, it replaces the gradient backgrounds in the code exactly where indicated below.

Overall Direction

Every illustration must read as **colored pencil or watercolor, hand-painted, archival paper texture, editorial quality** — the kind of artwork you'd find inside a bound keepsake book, or in the pages of Architectural Digest Mexico. Think storybook, not stock art.

DO	NEVER
Watercolor or colored-pencil texture, visible paper grain	Flat vector illustration or clip art
Muted, sun-warmed color — like an aged photograph	Saturated, neon, or "tropical postcard" colors
Talavera pattern used as abstract ornament, not literal tourist motif	Sombreros, maracas, cacti clichés, "fiesta" iconography
Soft, diffused light — golden hour, candlelight, dawn haze	Hard shadows, studio lighting, anything that reads "stock photo"
Two figures shown from behind, in silhouette, or partially — intimacy through restraint	Faces rendered front-on like a greeting card illustration

Reference Mood (study these, never copy)

- Amanjena — restrained, earthen luxury, never decorative for its own sake
- Chablé Yucatán — Mayan-influenced minimalism, stone and light
- Azulik Tulum — organic architecture, jungle-meets-craft
- Casa Malca — bohemian luxury without kitsch
- Architectural Digest Mexico / Vogue Weddings Mexico — editorial photography mood, not tourism brochure

Color Palette

These are the only colors that should appear in any illustration. No additions.



Ivory

Sand

Terracotta

Emerald



Aged Gold

Ocean Blue

Talavera Blue

Burnt Clay

Artwork Briefs, by Section

Opening — The Scratch Reveal

A hand-painted talavera-inspired medallion, viewed from directly above, as if printed on fine handmade paper. Concentric geometric and floral bands in talavera blue, terracotta, and aged gold against an ivory ground. At the absolute center: a small, quiet 'S' and 'L' monogram, rendered in the same hand-lettered style as the rest of the piece — not typeset. This is the single most important image in the entire experience: it is the first thing a guest's own hand uncovers. It must feel like uncovering a piece of pottery passed through generations, not a graphic.

File reference: *sl-scratch-reveal-bg.jpg / .png* · **Suggested size:** 1600 × 1600px (square, scales to any viewport)

Chapter One — Where It All Began

A sun-warmed classroom interior, golden afternoon light through tall windows, dust motes visible in the light beams. Two young figures shown small within the frame, from behind or in silhouette near a window — never posed, never looking at camera. The mood is memory, not scene-setting: slightly hazy, like recalling something fondly rather than photographing it. Warm ochre, sand, and soft amber dominate. A single potted plant or open notebook on a desk as the only literal detail — restraint is the point.

File reference: *sl-ch1-classroom.jpg* · **Suggested size:** 2400 × 1600px (landscape)

Chapter Two — Growing Together

Three small watercolor vignettes, each a single travel memory rendered loosely and impressionistically — a coastal road, a market stall glimpsed in passing, two cups of coffee on a worn café table. None should be a literal postcard view. Each should feel like a fragment pulled from a shared sketchbook: incomplete at the edges, color bleeding slightly into the paper. Palette shifts toward ocean blue and emerald for these three.

File reference: *sl-ch2-travel-01.jpg, sl-ch2-travel-02.jpg, sl-ch2-travel-03.jpg* · **Suggested size:** 1200 × 1500px each (portrait, sized to sit inside tilted 'polaroid' frames already built in code)

Chapter Three — The Proposal

The Tulum coastline at golden hour, viewed from elevation — limestone cliffs, turquoise water fading to deep ocean blue at the horizon, the sun low and warm. Two figures, very small in the frame, standing near the cliff's edge — distant enough that this reads as 'a moment in a vast and beautiful place,' not a posed photo. No visible ring, no kneeling pose — the emotion comes from scale and light, not from illustrating the literal act of a proposal.

File reference: *sl-ch3-tulum-coast.jpg* · **Suggested size:** 2400 × 1600px (landscape, full-bleed)

Chapter Four — The Ceremony / The Celebration / The Evening

Three quiet companion pieces. THE CEREMONY: an open-air altar structure under jungle canopy, soft diffused daylight, talavera details on a simple arch — no guests, no faces, just the space itself, expectant. THE CELEBRATION: an overhead view of a long outdoor table set with talavera ceramics and candlelight, place settings visible but unpeopled — like a painting of a table waiting to be filled. THE EVENING: the same setting at full dark,

string lights and candle glow only, warm amber dominating, a sense of music and motion implied through blurred light trails rather than illustrated dancers.

File reference: *sl-ch4-ceremony.jpg, sl-ch4-celebration.jpg, sl-ch4-evening.jpg* · **Suggested size:** 1600 × 2000px each (portrait)

Typography Pairing (already built into the code)

Headings use **Prata** (display serif) and **Cormorant/EB Garamond** (editorial italic) — both already loaded in the project. Labels and UI text use **Manrope**. No new fonts are required from the illustrator; artwork should simply leave clean negative space where this typography will sit, particularly in the upper-third or lower-third of each landscape image.

Delivery & Integration

- Deliver as JPG (photographic/painterly pieces) or PNG with transparency (the scratch-reveal medallion only).
- Once files are ready, drop them into /public/assets/sl/ using the filenames above, and send them back — the gradient placeholders in the code will be swapped for the real artwork directly.
- If using AI generation (Midjourney, etc.) as a first pass before a human illustrator refines it, use each brief above as the prompt directly — the level of specificity here is written to work as a generation prompt as much as a brief for a human artist.